trust. The Trusts were strongly convinced that a well-thought-out strategy should have been formulated, using the experience and wisdom of the main stakeholders. It believed that Mistry took recourse to the simplest course—disposing of the assets.

A hasty decision to sell the foreign assets could cast doubts on the genuineness of the avowed long-term commitment of the group towards assets they may acquire in the future. Foreign governments, whose support is imperative during takeovers, might look askance at the Tata Group's proposals for fear that the group would only be looking at short-term gains, putting the local employees in jeopardy.

Many analysts opined that Mistry's decision to get rid of assets that posed a challenge was self-defeating. The two decades of overseas expansion should have been followed by a phase of consolidation. It would have enhanced the returns from the new investments—a point that Ratan never tired of repeating, especially as, after the major overseas acquisitions, the larger part of Tata Sons' revenue came from abroad.

'Expand-then-refocus cycles are routine at multinationals. But there is little sign that Mr Mistry is inclined that way', and 'little of that consolidation has happened', opined *The Economist* in September 2016, a month before Mistry left the corner office of Bombay House. The harsh truth, many renowned Tata veterans opined, was that Mistry was unable to rise to his new responsibilities. In part, this was spawned by his lack of experience in steering any large conglomerate.

Commenting on the slow progress of the group under Mistry, *The Economist* said in the same article: 'For the moment, however, he [Mistry] appears dangerously content just to sit atop what has grown into an impressive but lumbering pachyderm.' Farokh Subedar, who was company secretary, Tata Sons, and chairman, Tata Asset Management Ltd, says that he 'will not give him [Mistry] marks for speed'.

With the supportive environment he had, Mistry could have pushed through some urgently needed reforms in the group. He should have focused on a hard relook at the companies that had become a drain on the resources and did not have long-term prospects. And, where possible, much-needed changes should have been introduced. But Mistry paid little attention to reforms. He 'failed to make it happen', wrote *The Economist* in an article in October 2016 after his ouster.